

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Banking Operations English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For bank operations staff, branch managers, loan operations teams, KYC/AML analysts, fraud operations staff, payment operations teams, compliance staff, and banking leaders.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Account Opening and KYC

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

02 AML Monitoring and Suspicious Activity

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

03 Loan Operations and Documentation

Clarify missing information before responding.

04 Payment Operations and Exceptions

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

05 Fraud Operations and Customer Escalation

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

06 Operational Risk and Controls

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

07 Audit and Regulatory Exams

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

08 Customer Complaints and Fair Treatment

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Account Opening and KYC

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

An account application lacks requested ownership information. The applicant asks staff to open the account before the review is complete.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: KYC, CIP, beneficial owner, risk rating.

Model response

Could you provide the outstanding ownership information through the approved channel? I can explain what is missing, but the application still needs to follow the bank's review process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Ownership information is still required for review - Fictional account-opening exercise: this application's existing request asks for Mira Chen's ownership percentage, which is missing. The application review is incomplete. This case-specific request is not a universal banking requirement; actual decisions follow current authorized procedures.

2. Identity evidence does not settle ownership - Separate fictional onboarding case: an applicant's identity document is received, while requested company ownership information remains outstanding.

3. A changed ownership chart needs a verified version - Separate fictional application case: two company ownership charts differ; neither is identified as current, and no onboarding decision is available.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A translated document needs the specified review

A fictional business applicant supplies a document in a language the onboarding reviewer cannot assess. The current process's translation requirements have not been checked. Request an authorized clarification rather than inventing a requirement or approving the application.

Role A: Onboarding coordinator: ask the review lead to confirm the applicable translation requirements.

Role B: Relationship manager: explain the applicant needs a specific request and realistic timing.

Possible opening: Could you confirm the applicable translation requirements so we give the applicant an accurate document request?

Success checks

- Avoid interpreting unverified ownership information.
- Request the applicable requirement from the authorized source.
- Keep approval and timing unpromised.

Add a complication: Someone suggests guessing the ownership details from familiar names in the document.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

AML Monitoring and Suspicious Activity

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A monitoring alert identifies unusual transactions. The analyst has not determined their explanation. The internal note must remain neutral.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: AML, structuring, SAR, tipping off.

Model response

The transactions differ from the expected pattern and require review. That is an observation, not a conclusion about intent. I'll document the relevant facts through the approved confidential process.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. B - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. A - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. An alert is not a finding of wrongdoing - Fictional internal anti-money-laundering review: a monitoring alert identifies unusual transactions, but their explanation is unknown. No detection thresholds or customer-contact tactics are discussed.

2. A familiar explanation is still unverified - Separate fictional internal review: a colleague suggests an unusual transfer pattern reflects seasonal business activity, but the case evidence has not established that explanation.
3. An incomplete record limits the comparison - Separate fictional monitoring case: an analyst compares current transactions with an earlier period, but the earlier-period extract is incomplete.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A business description is out of date

A fictional internal monitoring file contains an old business description, and a current alert is being compared against it. No updated description or explanation is verified. Discuss the limitation and the authorized review needed.

Role A: AML analyst: identify the age of the context without assuming the transactions are improper.

Role B: Review supervisor: ask what verified information is missing and keep communication within approved channels.

Possible opening: The alert is being compared with an old business description, so the context may not reflect current activity.

Success checks

- Preserve uncertainty about current business context.
- Avoid accusations or unsupported closure.
- Refer disclosure and further-information decisions through the authorized process.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to tell the customer exactly which monitoring rule generated the alert.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Loan Operations and Documentation

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A loan operations checklist marks a condition complete, but the supporting document refers to a different version of the agreement.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: loan boarding, collateral, condition precedent, exception.

Model response

Which agreement version governs this condition? Let's confirm the reference and required evidence before recording the item as complete in the operations checklist.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. Which agreement version supports the completed condition? - Fictional loan-operations review: a condition is marked complete, but its supporting document references a different agreement version; no funding authorization is given.
2. Received collateral document or verified collateral record? - Separate fictional loan-boarding case: a collateral document is received, but its asset reference has not been checked against the loan record.

3. An exception request is not an approved exception - Separate fictional loan-operations case: a record says exception submitted, while a team note shortens it to exception approved; the decision is unavailable.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A condition uses an undefined completion label

A fictional loan checklist says documents okay but gives no reviewer or supporting reference. The loan file contains several versions. Ask what the label means and which evidence supports it; no funding decision is supplied.

Role A: Loan operations specialist: request the reviewer, applicable version, and evidence behind the label.

Role B: Documentation coordinator: acknowledge the missing basis and seek authorized clarification.

Possible opening: Could you clarify what documents okay means here and which reviewed version supports that status?

Success checks

- Identify the ambiguous status and missing evidence.
- Request the authorized review basis.
- Avoid inferring funding permission.

Add a complication: The coordinator is asked to interpret the label as permission to release funds.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Payment Operations and Exceptions

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

CASE

A payments queue has 45 exceptions, with 30 reviewed and 15 pending. A manager asks whether all items have been resolved.

Teach this move

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Vocabulary to check: wire transfer, ACH, sanctions screening, exception queue.

Model response

Thirty exceptions have been reviewed, but review does not necessarily mean resolution. Fifteen are still pending review. I'll report the disposition status separately so the update is accurate.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Second-round challenge

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Language-check answers

1. C - The team has completed the review. 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.
2. B - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it. This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

05 • Conversations

1. Thirty reviewed does not mean thirty resolved - Fictional payment-operations update: 45 exceptions exist, 30 reviewed and 15 pending; resolution outcomes for the reviewed items are not supplied.
2. A batch is transmitted, acceptance is pending - Separate fictional payment case: an ACH file is transmitted; receiving-system acknowledgment is missing, and no settlement outcome is established.

3. A returned item still needs case follow-up - Separate fictional wire-transfer exception case: a return message is received, but the related account posting and customer communication remain unverified.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Queue counts use different timestamps

A fictional supervisor quotes 18 open payment exceptions from 09:00, while an analyst sees 12 at 10:00. No item-level change breakdown is available. Give a careful update and request the missing reconciliation of counts.

Role A: Payments analyst: identify the different timestamps and avoid inventing how six items changed status.

Role B: Operations supervisor: ask for the current count and the evidence needed to explain the change.

Possible opening: The counts come from different times; twelve are shown at ten, but we haven't verified the item-level changes.

Success checks

- State both timestamps and counts correctly.
- Avoid equating fewer exceptions with completed payments.
- Request the item-level status breakdown.

Add a complication: The supervisor wants to announce six completed payments from the count difference alone.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Fraud Operations and Customer Escalation

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A customer reporting a disputed transaction receives conflicting explanations of the process. The case outcome has not been determined.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: fraud claim, provisional credit, chargeback, dispute.

Model response

I'm sorry the explanations differed. Let me confirm the applicable process and your case status with the responsible team. I'll distinguish the next procedural step from any outcome that is still undecided.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. Correcting conflicting dispute explanations - Fictional fraud-operations coordination: a customer received conflicting process descriptions; the dispute outcome remains unknown. The dialogue is between a complaints liaison and case specialist.

2. A temporary credit was described as final - Separate fictional dispute case: the verified record labels a credit temporary, but a service message calls it final; no final case decision exists.

3. A callback was mistaken for case completion - Separate fictional fraud-claim case: an agent promised completion during a scheduled callback, but the case team agreed only to provide a progress update.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The wrong transaction was discussed

A fictional customer disputed transaction T8, but an agent's reply referred to T3. No outcome is known for T8. Correct the reference in a call between service and fraud operations, using only the synthetic identifiers.

Role A: Service supervisor: acknowledge the incorrect reference and ask for T8's verified process status.

Role B: Fraud case coordinator: keep both cases distinct and avoid transferring any outcome from T3.

Possible opening: Our reply referred to T3, but the customer's dispute concerns T8; we need to correct that mismatch.

Success checks

- Correct the transaction reference explicitly.
- Keep T8's outcome unknown.
- Arrange a case-specific status check through the approved channel.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to reuse T3's response without checking T8.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Operational Risk and Controls

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

CASE

A reconciliation is signed off even though one unmatched balance remains under investigation.

Teach this move

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Vocabulary to check: operational risk, control, reconciliation, remediation.

Model response

The reconciliation work has been performed, but the unmatched balance remains open. I'll show that exception and its review status instead of implying that every item has been resolved.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Second-round challenge

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Language-check answers

1. A - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed. This gives the meaning in familiar words.
2. C - How would you describe the next step in your own words? An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

05 • Conversations

1. Signed off does not mean every balance matched - Fictional operational-control discussion: a reconciliation is signed off while one unmatched balance remains under investigation; sign-off meaning has not been clarified.
2. A control description is not evidence of operation - Separate fictional risk review: a team has documented a daily control but has not supplied records showing it operated during the review period.

3. Fixing one item versus changing the process - Separate fictional operational-risk case: one erroneous internal entry has been corrected, but the process that produced it has not yet been assessed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A completed checklist has an unresolved exception

A fictional control checklist is fully ticked, but an attached exception remains open. The meaning of the ticks has not been defined for the review. Explain why the attachment and checklist must be considered together.

Role A: Control analyst: distinguish a completed checklist from resolved exceptions.

Role B: Operations manager: ask what the ticks mean and who owns the open item.

Possible opening: The checklist is filled in, but the attached exception remains open and needs its own status explanation.

Success checks

- Keep the exception visible.
- Request clarification of checklist meaning.
- Avoid treating completed paperwork as proof of resolved risk.

Add a complication: The manager wants to remove the attachment from the briefing to avoid questions.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Audit and Regulatory Exams

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

An examination request asks for evidence of a control operating over a stated period. The team has only the policy document ready.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: examiner, audit evidence, finding, management response.

Model response

Could you identify the records that demonstrate the control's operation during the requested period? The policy describes the process, but we also need the relevant evidence of its use.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. C - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. B - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. Request evidence for the stated examination period - Fictional examination preparation: a request asks for control-operation evidence over a stated period; only the policy document is ready.
2. The sample is ready but its approvals are missing - Separate fictional internal audit: transaction samples are collected, but linked review approvals requested by the auditor are not included.

3. Ask what the management response still needs - Separate fictional examination follow-up: a draft management response says action taken but omits the action owner and supporting evidence; no finding closure is confirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The evidence request names an unclear system

A fictional audit request asks for access-review records from the platform, but the team uses two platforms. The review period is specified; the platform is not. Clarify the system before collecting evidence.

Role A: Audit coordinator: request the exact platform and explain why it affects evidence selection.

Role B: Control owner: identify the ambiguity and agree to seek the requester's clarification.

Possible opening: Could you confirm which platform the request covers so we collect the correct records for the stated period?

Success checks

- Identify the missing system scope.
- Preserve the stated review period.
- Use authorized, relevant evidence sharing rather than indiscriminate disclosure.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests sending all records from both systems without checking relevance or access permissions.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Customer Complaints and Fair Treatment

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A customer asks why a fee was charged. The representative has a current fee schedule but has not checked the transaction details.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: complaint, fee disclosure, error resolution, fair treatment.

Model response

I can explain the published fee schedule, and I'll ask the responsible team to review how it applies to this transaction. I do not want to give you an unverified explanation of the charge.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. The fee schedule does not settle this charge - Fictional complaint-coordination rehearsal: a current fee schedule is available, but its applicability to the customer's transaction has not been checked. The liaison practices a customer-facing correction with the reviewer.

2. A current schedule was used for an older charge - Separate fictional complaint case: an agent explained a prior-period charge using the current fee schedule; the applicable earlier terms remain unverified.

3. A fee-review request was described as a refund - Separate fictional case: a representative submitted a fee-review request but told the customer a refund was approved; no refund decision is recorded.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The complaint channel was stated incorrectly

A fictional customer was told a fee complaint could only be discussed in person. The supplied current service instruction also allows an authenticated phone appointment. No decision on the fee is available. Correct the channel information without generalizing to other banks.

Role A: Service supervisor: acknowledge the incorrect channel restriction and offer the verified phone option.

Role B: Customer advocate: explain the customer's difficulty attending and ask how an appointment can be arranged.

Possible opening: Our earlier message incorrectly limited the discussion to an in-person visit; this service also offers an authenticated phone appointment.

Success checks

- Correct the channel information using only the supplied instruction.
- Separate access to discussion from a complaint outcome.
- Agree an appointment-arrangement check without bypassing authentication.

Add a complication: The advocate asks you to promise a refund during that appointment.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

FinCEN: customer identification guidance

<https://www.fincen.gov/resources/statutes-regulations/guidance/interagency-interpretive-guidance-customer-identification>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-28. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Banking Operations English

Professional audience: bank operations staff, branch managers, loan operations teams, KYC/AML analysts, fraud operations staff, payment operations teams, compliance staff, and banking leaders

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Account Opening and KYC

Original fictional case: An account application lacks requested ownership information. The applicant asks staff to open the account before the review is complete.

Language workshop: Ask for an actionable next step

Communication goal: Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

Language guidance: State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Could you provide ... so that ...? / Please confirm ... by [agreed time]. / If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Vocabulary: KYC: Know-your-customer process used to verify a customer's identity, ownership, and risk profile. / CIP: Customer Identification Program: a bank's program for identifying customers under applicable US requirements. / beneficial owner: Natural person who ultimately owns or controls an entity or receives its economic benefit. / risk rating: A category or score assigned using defined criteria to describe a risk.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you provide the outstanding ownership information through the approved channel? I can explain what is missing, but the application still needs to follow the bank's review process.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Banking Operations English

Professional audience: bank operations staff, branch managers, loan operations teams, KYC/AML analysts, fraud operations staff, payment operations teams, compliance staff, and banking leaders

Scope: Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Lesson 01: Account Opening and KYC

Original fictional case: An account application lacks requested ownership information. The applicant asks staff to open the account before the review is complete.

Language workshop: Ask for an actionable next step

Communication goal: Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

Language guidance: State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): Could you provide ... so that ...? / Please confirm ... by [agreed time]. / If that timing is not possible, please let me know ...

Vocabulary: KYC: Know-your-customer process used to verify a customer's identity, ownership, and risk profile. / CIP: Customer Identification Program: a bank's program for identifying customers under applicable US requirements. / beneficial owner: Natural person who ultimately owns or controls an entity or receives its economic benefit. / risk rating: A category or score assigned using defined criteria to describe a risk.

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Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Could you provide the outstanding ownership information through the approved channel? I can explain what is missing, but the application still needs to follow the bank's review process.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level